Olympic Swim Star Tatjana Smith Switches to the Netherlands

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South Africa's most decorated Olympian, Tatjana Smith, was in tears as she announced that she has switched **allegiance** to the Netherlands.

The 29-year-old won four Olympic **breaststroke** medals, including two golds, before retiring after the Paris 2024 Games. She came out of **retirement** in September and hopes to compete in the 50m **breaststroke** as the event makes its Olympic debut at the 2028 Games in Los Angeles.

Smith, whose maiden name was Schoenmaker, wiped away tears as she read a letter addressed to South Africa, saying that 'dreams can change as we grow.'

Smith has **dual citizenship** because her father is Dutch. She said she has 'always been Dutch and South African' and that this is an opportunity to 'explore another part of my identity and heritage that I've never experienced through sport.'

She said it also offers her 'greater high-performance support and the potential to build a more **sustainable** career' because the 'financial and practical challenges of swimming were among the reasons my previous career became difficult to sustain.' Smith has previously said that financial worries, which included a **dispute** with Swimming South Africa over prize money, contributed to her decision to step away from the sport. Swimming South Africa has been approached for comment.

Smith won four world and Commonwealth gold medals between 2018 and 2023. She won gold in the 200m **breaststroke** and 100m silver at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021, before adding 100m gold and 200m silver in 2024.

'Representing South Africa was a childhood dream come true, and it's a chapter I will always look back on with immense pride and gratitude,' she said on social media. 'The people, the memories and everything we achieved together will always be part of me. But dreams can change as we grow. This next chapter is about embracing another part of who I am, falling in love with the journey and discovering what more I'm capable of. I'm excited for what lies ahead, and I truly hope you'll continue to be part of the journey with me.'

Smith, who said she will continue to live and train in South Africa, is set to represent the Netherlands for the first time at the short course World Championships from 1-6 December. She acknowledged that her switch 'may disappoint or break the hearts' of some supporters. The Ministry of Sport, Arts and Culture in South Africa said it was aware of the 'problems at Swimming South Africa.' 'The country was delighted to see her return to the pool, but South Africa does not own her,' a statement read.

Word Treasure

allegiance -- Allegiance means loyalty to a country or team.

breaststroke -- Breaststroke is a swimming style where both arms move together in a circle.

dual citizenship -- Dual citizenship means being a citizen of two countries at once.
retirement -- Retirement means stopping work or sport after a long career.
sustainable -- Sustainable means able to keep going for a long time.
dispute -- A dispute is a disagreement or argument.

Background you need

The Olympic Games are the world's biggest sports event, where athletes compete for their countries in many sports, including swimming.

In swimming, the breaststroke is a style where the swimmer moves both arms together in a circular motion and kicks like a frog.

Some athletes hold citizenship in two countries, which means they can sometimes choose which country to represent in competition.

The 50m breaststroke is a short, fast sprint race that will be swum at the Olympics for the first time in 2028.

Break it down

LEAD: South Africa's most decorated Olympian, Tatjana Smith, will now swim for the Netherlands.

KEY EVENT: Smith announced the switch in tears, reading a letter to South Africa.

+- WHO: Tatjana Smith, 29, a four-time Olympic breaststroke medalist

+- WHAT: Switching allegiance to the Netherlands, where her father is from

+- WHEN: Announced now; first race for the Netherlands at the short course World Championships, 1-6 December

EVIDENCE: Smith says she has 'always been Dutch and South African' and wants greater support and a more sustainable career.

OPEN QUESTION: How will she do in the 50m breaststroke at its Olympic debut in Los Angeles in 2028?

Why it matters

Athletes sometimes face hard choices about where they belong, and Smith's story shows that identity and dreams can change as we grow.

Test what you remember

1. Which country will Tatjana Smith now swim for?

- (A) The United States
- (B) South Africa
- (C) The Netherlands
- (D) Australia

2. How many Olympic breaststroke medals did Smith win?

- (A) Eight
- (B) Two
- (C) Six
- (D) Four

3. When did Smith come out of retirement?

- (A) After the Tokyo Olympics
- (B) In December
- (C) In September
- (D) In January

4. What event does Smith hope to compete in at the 2028 Games?

- (A) The 50m breaststroke
- (B) The 100m freestyle
- (C) The 400m medley
- (D) The 200m butterfly

5. Why does Smith have dual citizenship?

- (A) Because she was born in the Netherlands
- (B) Because her father is Dutch
- (C) Because she trained in the Netherlands
- (D) Because she married a Dutch swimmer

6. When will Smith first represent the Netherlands?

- (A) At the 2028 Games in Los Angeles
- (B) At the Paris 2024 Games
- (C) At the short course World Championships from 1-6 December
- (D) At the Tokyo Olympics

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Tatjana Smith: Says the switch lets her explore another part of her identity and gives her greater support and a more sustainable career.

2. South Africa's Ministry of Sport, Arts and Culture: Says the country was delighted to see her return to the pool, but South Africa does not own her.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):